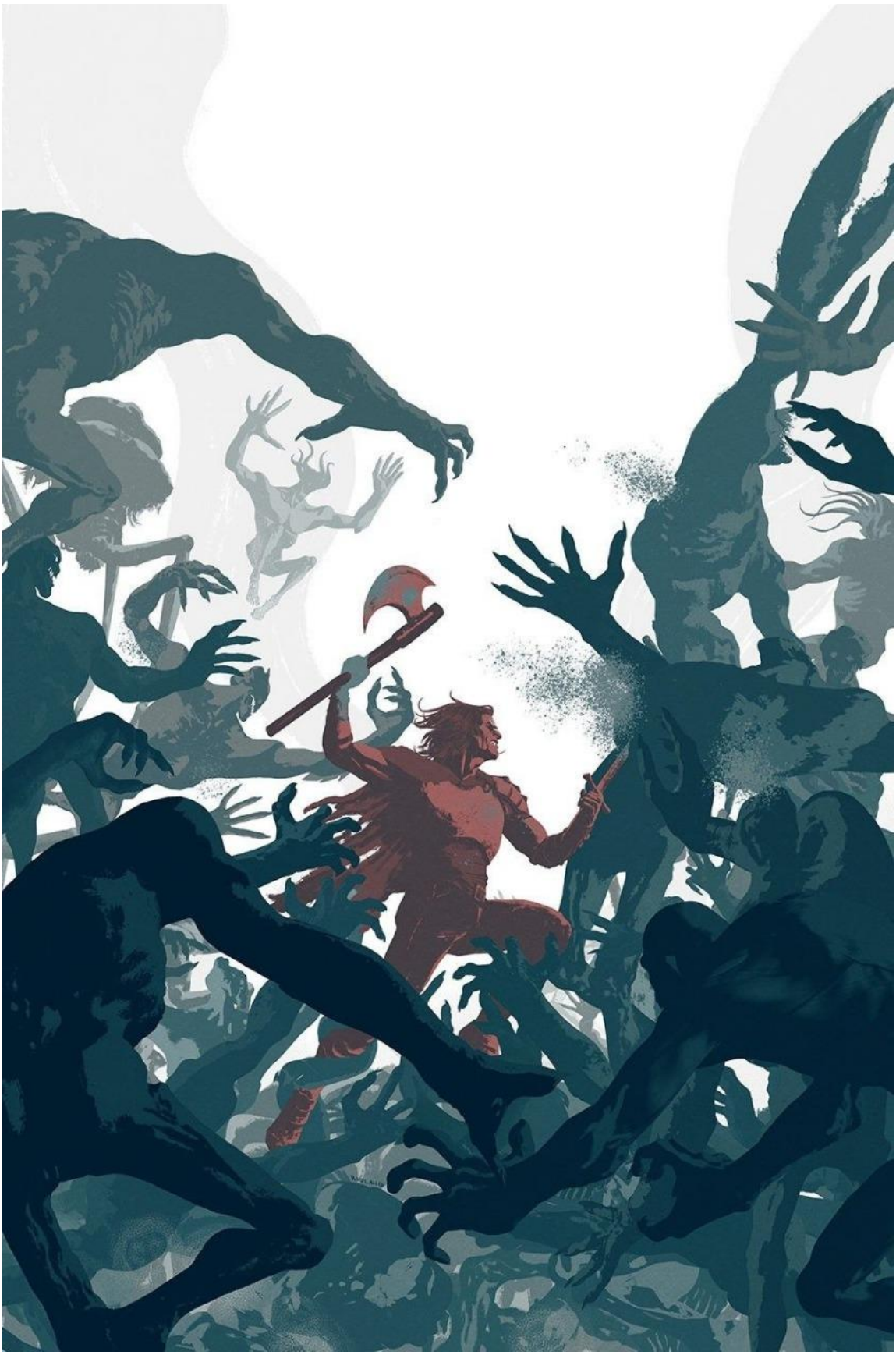


# THE LAST STAND OF KAEL

BY

JAMES SMITH

The world, as Kael knew it, had died in a single, agonizing night. He had been a simple woodsman, a man of the forest, who knew the language of trees and the whispers of the wind. His axe, a cherished heirloom from his father, was used for felling pines and splitting logs, not for splitting bone and severing limbs. Now, it was a bloody extension of his arm, a grim partner in a dance of death he had never asked to learn.

The plague had come on the wings of a silent, sickly wind. It turned men, women, and children into the things that now swarmed him—grotesque parodies of their former selves, their eyes milky and vacant, their mouths agape in silent screams. They were the husks, the walking dead, driven by an insatiable hunger for the living.

Kael stood at the heart of the storm, a lone island of fire in a sea of encroaching darkness. He was a beacon of defiance, his body a testament to the brutal, beautiful will to survive. His muscles, honed by a life of hard labor, screamed in protest, but he

pushed them harder, his mind a steel trap of focus. His red tunic, once the color of a summer sunset, was now a tapestry of mud, grime, and the dark, viscous ichor of his foes.

A husk lunged from his left, its clawed hand outstretched, its jaw unhinged. Kael's axe met it with a sickening crunch, the momentum carrying the husk's head from its shoulders. A second one followed, a woman he vaguely recognized from the village square, a baker's wife. He flinched, a flicker of a memory of her kind smile crossing his mind, but the moment was fleeting. He thrust his knife, a small but lethal tool he usually used for carving wood, into its chest. The blade found no heart, only dead sinew, but it was enough to drive it back.

The husks came in waves, a relentless tide of misery and despair. They were a cacophony of shuffling feet and guttural moans, a symphony of the damned. Kael was an artist in this grim orchestra, his movements a brutal ballet of blocks, parries, and strikes. He dodged a grasping hand, ducked under a

flailing arm, and spun, his axe a whirlwind of destruction. Each blow was a final act of mercy, a grim goodbye to the souls trapped within these shambling prisons.

He was tired. So incredibly tired. The weight of the world, of this new, terrible world, pressed down on him. He had seen his wife, Elara, become one of them. He had seen his son, Finn, fall to the plague. The memories were a fresh wound, a constant source of pain that fueled his rage and his resolve. He fought not just for his life, but for their memory. He fought so that their deaths would not be in vain, so that their love would not be forgotten in this world of hate.

A shadow loomed over him, a husk larger than the others, a hulking brute of a man who had once been the village blacksmith. Its calloused hands, once used to shape iron, were now instruments of death. It roared, a sound that was more rustle of dead leaves than human voice, and lunged. Kael met its charge head-on, his axe held high. The impact was bone-

jarring, and Kael's arm screamed in protest, but he held his ground. He gritted his teeth, pushed back, and with a final, guttural roar, brought his axe down, severing the husk’s arm at the shoulder. The brute stumbled back, its momentum broken, and Kael followed through, his blade finding its mark.

He stood panting, his chest heaving, the air burning his lungs. The husks, for a moment, seemed to hesitate, their mindless hunger momentarily halted by the display of pure, unadulterated will. But the pause was brief. They surged forward again, a new wave of death ready to engulf him.

Kael looked up at the sky, a pale, anemic gray that offered no hope. He thought of Elara, her laugh like the chime of a bell. He thought of Finn, his son’s bright, curious eyes. A single tear, a testament to his lost humanity, carved a path through the grime on his cheek.

He was not a king. He was not a knight. He was just Kael, a man who had loved his family and his life. And now, he was a warrior, a defender of a past that was

gone forever. He held his axe in a two-handed grip, his stance wide and ready. The glint of steel was his only comfort, the roar of battle his only prayer.

He took a deep breath, and as the husks closed in, he charged. He was the last stand. He was the end of an era. And in his final, glorious moments, he was, undeniably, alive. His legacy would not be a tombstone, but the whisper of a name on the wind, a story told by those few who survived: the story of Kael, the man who fought the darkness, even when the sun had died.